

Minglai Yang

Tucson – United States

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Education

University of Arizona

B.S. in Computer Science

Tucson

2023–2025

- GPA: 4.0 / 4.0
- Expected Graduation: December 2025 (complete in 2 years)
- Relevant coursework available [here](#).

Research Experience

The University of Arizona, CLU-LAB

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Tucson, AZ

Oct 2024 – Present

- Advisor: Prof. Mihai Surdeanu and Dr. Liangming Pan
- Leading Research Project on analyzing large language models' reasoning ([EMNLP](#) - First Author).
- Collaborated with Dr. Chicheng Zhang to develop LLM-guided warm starts for RL, achieving 20× higher data efficiency ([EXAIT@ICML Workshop](#)).
- Conducting research with Dr. Vikas Yadav on speculative decoding strategies for LLMs ([EMNLP](#)).

Tsinghua University, Knowledge Engineering Group

Visiting Researcher

Beijing, China

May 2025 – Aug 2025

- Advisor: Prof. Juanzi Li
- Directed a research project on mechanistic interpretability of reasoning processes in reinforcement learning-based LLMs.
- Co-authoring a survey paper on reasoning mechanisms in LLMs.

The University of Arizona, ML4AI-LAB and IVI-LAB

Undergraduate Research Assistant

Tucson, AZ

Oct 2023 – Present

- Advisor: Prof. Kobus Barnard and Dr. Adarsh Pyarelal
- Developing dynamic Bayesian networks and Theory of Mind models within the [ToMCAT](#) project to improve AI modeling of human coordination.
- Designing probabilistic models to disentangle causal interpersonal coordination from correlation.

Publications

1. *How Is LLM Reasoning Distracted by Irrelevant Context? An Analysis Using a Controlled Benchmark*
Minglai Yang, Ethan Huang, Liang Zhang, Mihai Surdeanu, William Wang, Liangming Pan
EMNLP 2025 — Main Conference (CORE A)*, 2025 [\[preprint\]](#) [\[code\]](#) [\[slides\]](#) [\[poster\]](#)
2. *CopySpec: Accelerating LLMs with Speculative Copy-and-Paste Without Compromising Quality*
Razvan Dumitru, **Minglai Yang**, Vikas Yadav, Mihai Surdeanu
EMNLP 2025 — Main Conference (CORE A)*, 2025 [\[preprint\]](#) [\[code\]](#)
3. *Improving the Data-efficiency of Reinforcement Learning by Warm-starting with LLM*
Thang Duong, **Minglai Yang**, Chicheng Zhang
Exploration in AI Today (EXAIT) Workshop @ ICML, 2025 [\[preprint\]](#) [\[code\]](#)

Honors and Awards

2025: Galileo Circle Scholar (Top 0.8% Academic Award), College of Science, University of Arizona

2023–2025: Academic Highest Distinction (Dean's List) (6 times), University of Arizona

2023–2025: Global Wildcat Scholarship, University of Arizona

2021: Shanghai High School, Second Prize, Shanghai Municipal Government

2020: Shanghai Youth Science and Technology Innovation Competition, Third Prize, Shanghai Nanyang Model High School

2018: China National Arts Competition, First Prize (Group), Shanghai Nanyang Model High School

Working Experience

Coretechs

Kensington, MD

Machine Learning Engineer Intern (Full Time)

May 2024 – Aug 2024

- Developed GPT-powered Slack bots with retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) and integrated real-time Slack chat into the official website using JavaScript, increasing active user engagement by 57%.
- Led end-to-end website development, from design to deployment, leveraging AWS (EC2, RDS, S3), Nginx, and Docker for scalable infrastructure.
- Conducted rigorous performance testing with Selenium, simulating 500+ concurrent users to ensure system reliability under high load.
- Received the *Best Intern Award* for outstanding contributions to the company's first Gen-AI project.

The University of Arizona, AI Core

Tucson, AZ

AI Engineer (Part Time)

Feb 2024 – Dec 2024

- Built tool-calling AI agents with Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) for internal knowledge; trained a custom long-context documentation QA model, improving top-1 accuracy by 48% on internal benchmarks.
- Designed and shipped an end-to-end campus chatbot website serving 50,000+ UA students with long-context retrieval; increased student web engagement by 5.39× post-launch.

Leadership and Extracurricular Activities

AI Club, University of Arizona

Tucson, AZ

President

Aug 2024 – Present

- Organized workshops on AI agents and LLM applications, including a Hack Arizona event with 100+ participants.
- Led weekly lectures and invited speaker sessions to foster AI learning across disciplines.
- Organized a reading group that mentors students interested in AI research.
- Raised over \$12,000 in sponsorships to support club activities and student research projects.

Mathematical Contest in Modeling (MCM), University of Arizona

Tucson, AZ

Team Leader & First Author

Sep 2023 – Mar 2024

- Led weekly tutoring sessions on mathematical modeling, convex optimization, Bayesian inference, and deep neural network methods.
- Developed mathematical models for the 2024 MCM problem on sea lamprey ecosystems, focusing on resource availability and sex ratio dynamics.

Student Union at University of Arizona

Tucson, AZ

Student Media Worker

Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

- Hosted large-scale showcase and orientation events, welcoming over 1,000 new students to the university.
- Organized and supported student engagement programs, strengthening outreach and inclusion on campus.

Teaching

Fall 2025: TA, CSC-244: Discrete Mathematics II, Computer Science, University of Arizona

Spring 2025: TA, CSC-144: Discrete Mathematics I, Computer Science, University of Arizona

Fall 2024 – Spring 2025: Instructor, Math for AI Workshop Series, AI Club, University of Arizona